

189. Pottery from the farm at Wadi Khallet el-Badd: 1. Bowl, lt br, Byz; 2. Crater base, dk, MA; 3-4. Jar and jug, br, Byz; 5-7. Dec shards, MA.



190. The farm at Wadi Khallet el-Badd, looking west. The site is on a built step on a small ravine, part of the hilly area north of Wadi Malih. It contains a structure with rooms and a square courtyard. Spring 1992.

Site 81: 19 – 19/74/4

Khirbet esh-Shaqq (Guérin: Kh. ech-Chekeb)

Israel grid: 1972 1946

UTM grid: 7353 5817

Elevation: 95 m b.s.l., 20 m a.s.a.

Name type: historical place on map

Site type: large ruin

Area: 15 dunams (3.75 acres)

Topography: valley edge and flat hilltop

Rock type: Tiberias formation

Soil type: rendzina and Mediterranean

brown forest soil; quality: 6

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 4

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain esh-Shaqq, no. 89), next to site

Nearest road: Tubas – Meholah (B8), passes by site

Visibility: 4

Apr. 8, 1988; 61 shards

* * *

A large ruin on a low, flat hilltop in the southwest part of esh-Shaqq Valley. It is situated between Wadi esh-Shaqq in the south and a deep

ravine in the north, a tributary of the same wadi. The site is located 3 km southwest of Meholah.

On the flat hilltop is a large com-



191. Aerial photo of the large site of Kh. esh-Shaqq, looking southeast. The site covers the low hill in the center. At right is the gorge of Wadi esh-Shaqq, while at left there is a new trench. Note the remnants of the structures seen on the surface. 1993.

plex of constructions about 40x70 m in size, including a central courtyard and various structures around it. It consists of the yard measuring 15X25 m, with several 'wings' attached to it. To its west there is a series of rooms in two rows, interwoven in each other. To the southeast there is another 'wing' with long, large rooms. The central yard is closed in the north by long halls. Other series of rooms are to the north of the complex, near the central trench. Southwest of the central complex and beyond a dirt road is a separate complex with 15-20 units, about 10x50 m in size. All the buildings are built of medium sized stones, and the plans suggest

at least two building stages at the site. The southwestern unit is built of large stones and apparently dates to an earlier period than the central complex.

Two concrete dams are located in Wadi esh-Shaqq, possibly built on earlier foundations. Along the rocky side of the wadi, to the north, a built and hewn *aqueduct* was found. Above the western dam, to the south, there is a large, hewn winepress 3x3.5 m in size, with a deep, plastered vat for new wine. A depression hewn in the floor of the winepress suggests a rock removal for another installation.

Guérin and Robinson visited the site and mentioned it, but it does



192. A view of the rocky canyon of Wadi edh-Dhb'ah, a small tributary of Wadi esh-Shaqq, looking west. It is near Kh. esh-Shaqq and to the north of it. 1993.

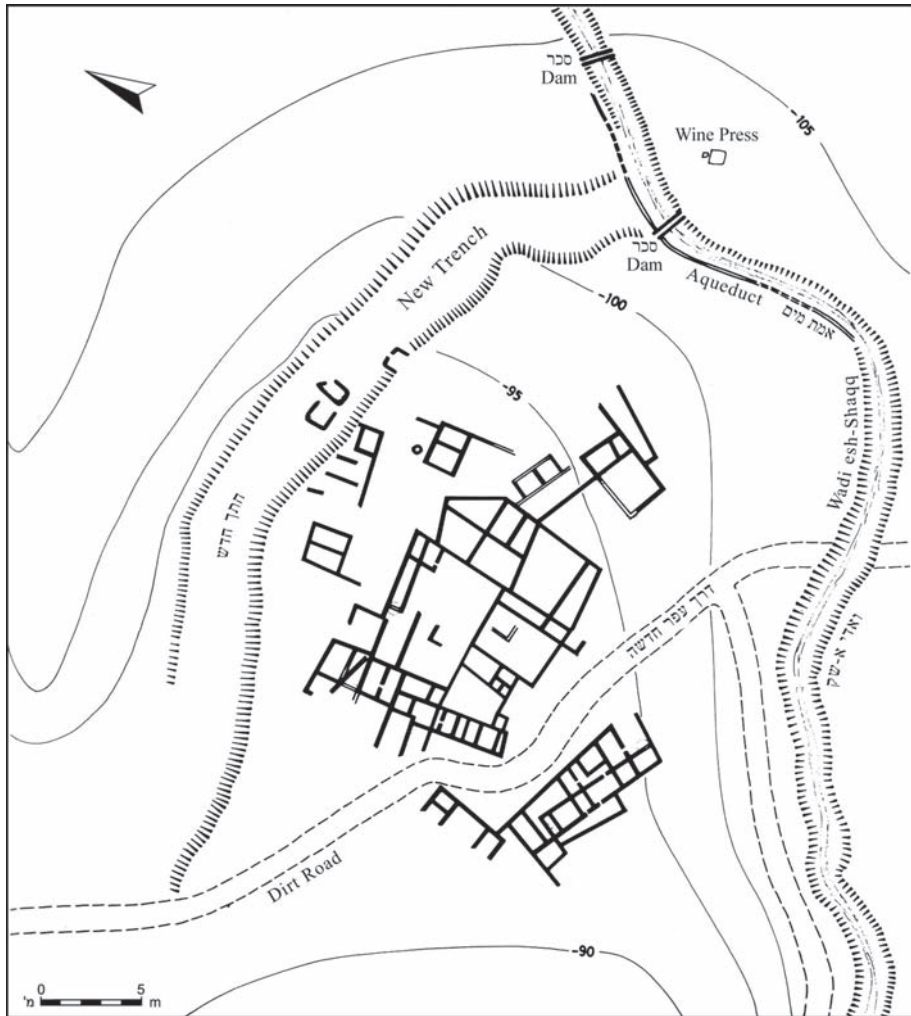
not appear on the SWP map.

Pottery: Byz – 95%; EM – 5%.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Po-

rath 1972, no. 70.

Bibliography: Robinson 1970, 405; Guérin 1969 (IV), 275-276; Conder 1876b, 15; Zertal 1988b, 83.



193. Plan of the site of Kh. esh-Shaqq between the Shaqq and Dhb'ah Wadis. It includes a central complex of buildings and another unit west of the dirt road with rooms. Along Wadi esh-Shaqq are dams, a winepress and a built *aqueduct*.

Site 82: 19 – 19/74/1

Khirbet Umm Ghazal (Kh. esh-Shaqq)

Israel grid: 1975 1945

UTM grid: 7354 5815

Elevation: 80 m b.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name type: historical place on map

Site type: fortress

Area: 2 dunams (0.5 acre)

Topography: high ridge

Rock type: Tiberias formation

Soil type: rendzina and Mediterranean

brown forest soil; quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain esh-Shaqq, no. 89), 0.1 km distant

Nearest road: Tubas – Meholah (B8), passes by site

Visibility: 5

Apr. 1, 1986; 80 shards and 11 flint items

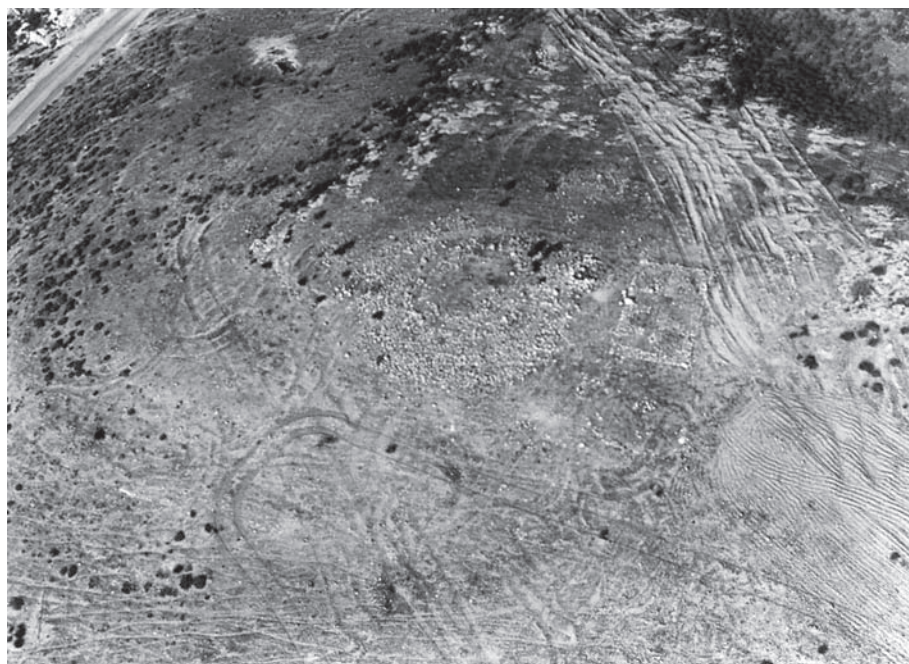
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A fortress on a ridge, above the southern fringes of esh-Shaqq Valley.

The fortress consists of three

parts:

1. A round structure 20 m in diameter, composed of three concentric circles, with internal division



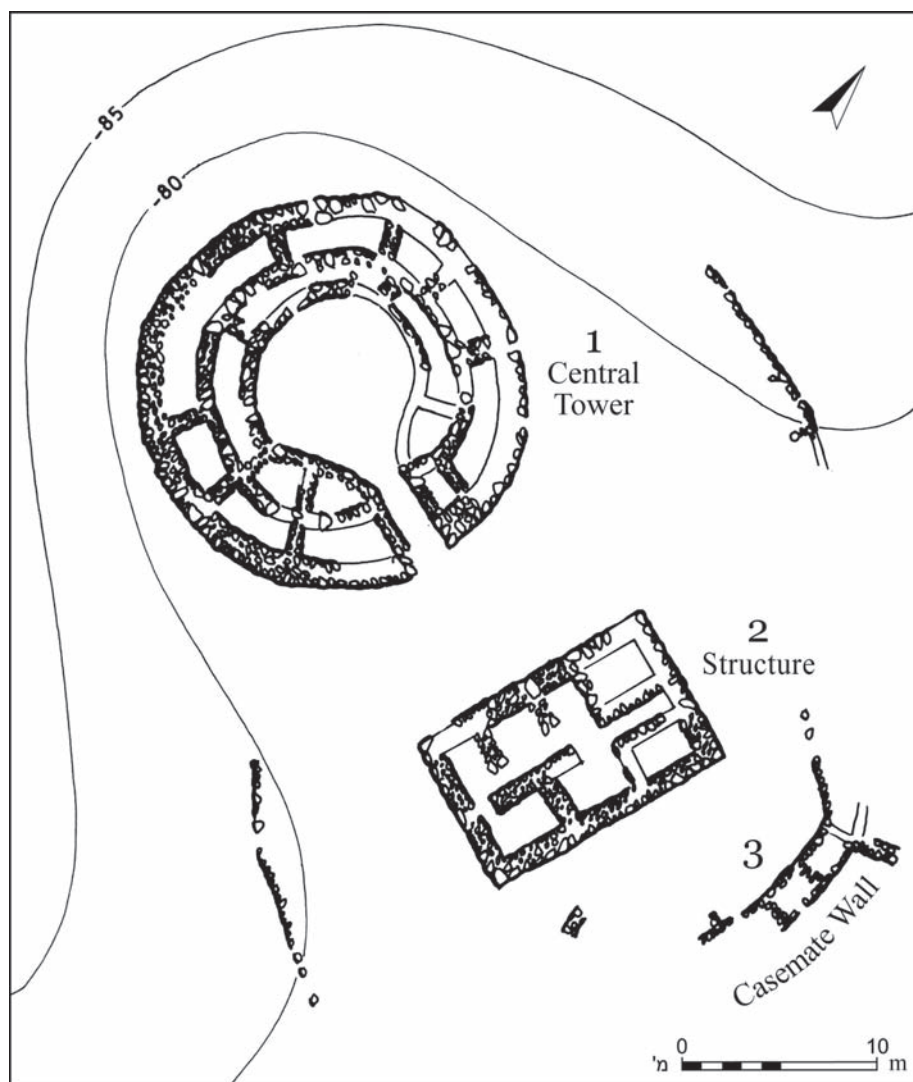
194. Aerial photo of the round Israelite fortress at Kh. Umm Ghazal. The fortress is seen in the center, with its three circles. At right is the building with seven rooms. Winter 1993.

into cells. The entrance is from the east; the walls are 1 m wide;

2. A rectangular structure built of field stones, 10x15 m in size and close to the round fortress. It is composed of seven rooms and its entrance is from the west;

3. Part of a casemate wall is seen east of the above. This apparently surrounded the entire site. A considerable shard scatter was found.

This fortress is similar to those discovered and excavated at el-Makhruq (site no. 269 here) and



195. Plan of the round fortress at Kh. Umm Ghazal. The site is on a ridge above Wadi esh-Shaqq, and identical fortresses were found at the entrance to Wadi Far'ah and the ascent from the Jordan Valley to 'Aqrabeh.

Rujjum Abu Mukheir. It turns out that they all controlled the roads that ascends from the Jordan Valley to the Samarian Hills.

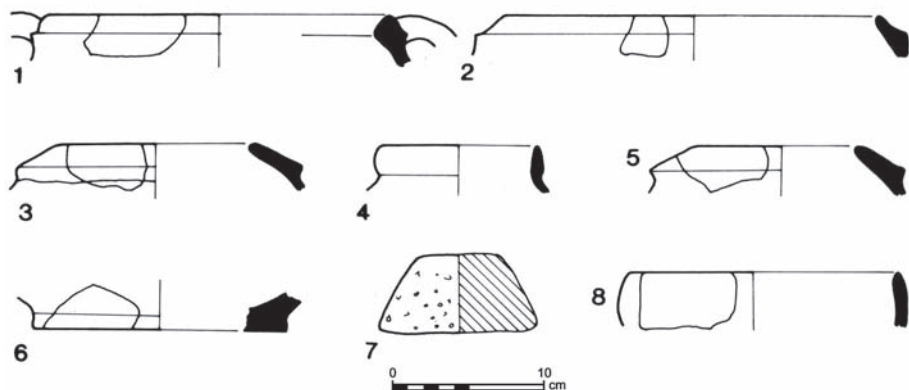
Pottery: IrA II – 80%; IrA III – 20%.

Flint find: 11 identifiable items; ‘Canaanite blade’ dating to Early

to MBA I. The geometrical blade is typical of the IrA; see appendix.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972, no. 71. They found there “foundations of solitary structures on a ridge edge”.

Bibliography: Robinson 1970, 405; Zertal 1988b, 83-86.



196. Pottery from the fortress at Kh. Umm Ghazal, all from IrA II: 1. CP, dk; 2. CP, dk, C type; 3, 5. HM jar, br; 4. Jar, yel; 6. Crater base, br; 7. Weight, basalt; 8. Bowl, br.



Site 83: 19 – 19/74/3

Muntar esh-Shaqq (on SWP map: Muntar esh-Shukk)

Israel grid: 1978 1944

UTM grid: 7358 5815

Elevation: 35 m b.s.l., 80 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient but not on map

Site type: fortress

Area: 1 dunam (0.25 acre)

Topography: high summit

Rock type: Tiberias formation

Soil type: rendzina and Mediterranean

brown forest soil; quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 3

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain esh-Shaqq, no. 89), 0.8 km distant

Nearest road: Tubas – Meholah (B8), 0.4 km distant

Visibility: 9

Apr. 1, 1988; 65 shards and 9 flint items

A fortress on a tall hill south of esh-Shaqq Valley, 2.5 km south-southwest of Meholah. From the site there is a view of the delta of Wadi Malih, the southern Beth Shean Valley and parts of the Gilead Mountains.

In the center of the summit is a structure about 8 m in diameter, now covered by a pile of stones. Inside it remnants of walls are discernible, and remains of a casemate wall are discerned north and west of it. This casemate wall consists of two parallel walls and connecting walls. Possible remains of more buildings are west of the central

structure. Dug out caves were also found north and south of the site. A considerable shard scatter is spread over the area.

This fortress presumably guarded the road through Wadi esh-Shaqq. When abandoned, it seems to have been replaced by the fortress of Kh. Umm Ghazal.

Pottery: IrA IB-IC – 100%.

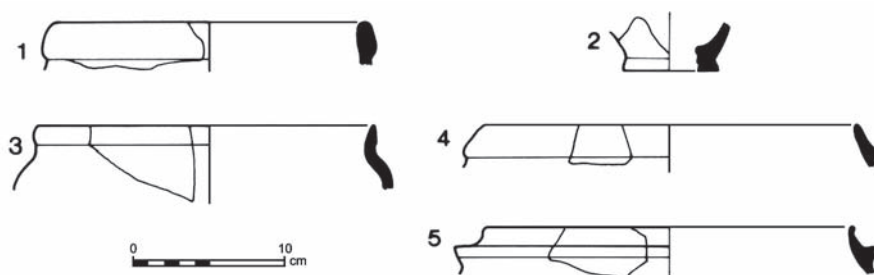
Flint find: Nine items from the Neolithic Period; see appendix.

Previous surveys: none.

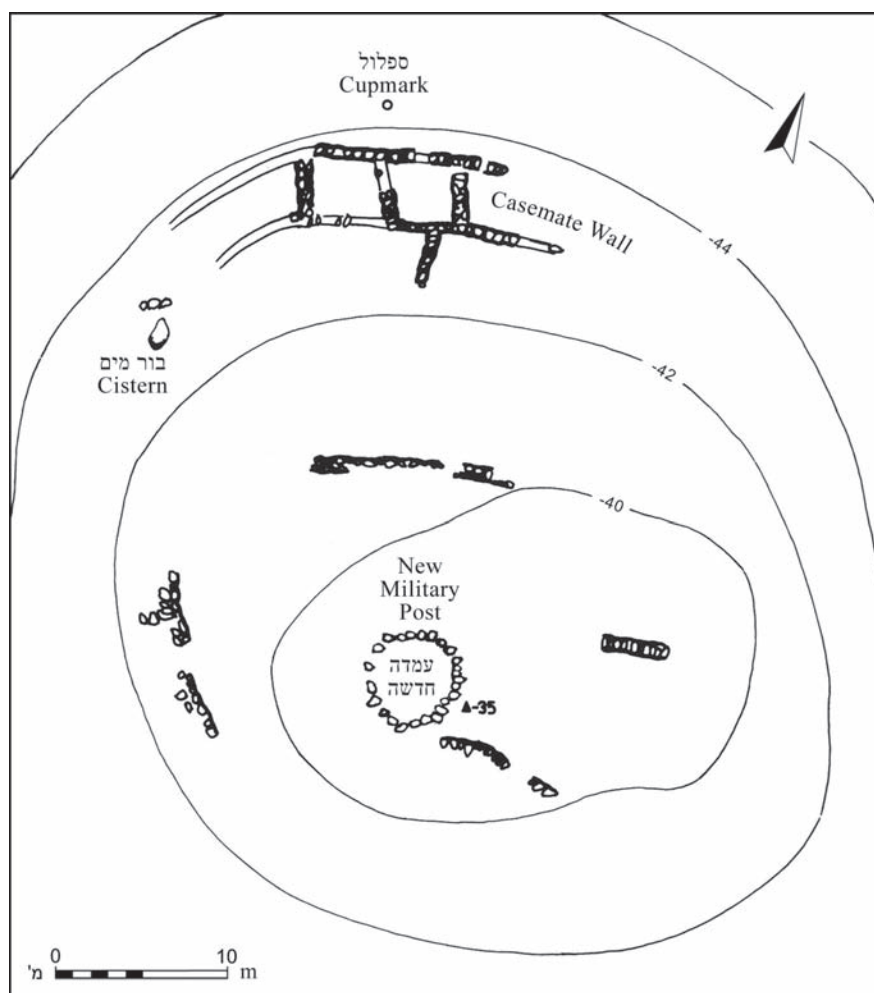
Bibliography: SWP II, 243; Zertal 1988b, 83-86.



197. The hill of Muntar esh-Shaqq, on whose summit the casemate fortress is situated. On the ridge at right is Kh. Umm Ghazal. The photo was taken from the plains of esh-Shaqq Valley. 1988.



198. Pottery from the fortress at Muntar esh-Shaqq, all from IrA IB and IC: 1. Pythos, dk; 2. Jug base, lt br; 3. Crater, br; 4-5. CP, dk.



199. Plan of the casemate fortress from Iron Age I on the summit of Muntar esh-Shaqq.

Site 84: 18 – 19/93/2

Khirbet el-‘Aqabeh (on SWP map: Khirbet el-Akabeh)

Israel grid: 1896 1935

UTM grid: 7274 5802

Elevation: 300 m a.s.l., 60 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient but not on map

Site type: medium sized ruin

Area: 6.1 dunams (1.5 acres)

Topography: hilltop and valley

Rock type: Judah formation

Soil type: terra rossa and Mediterra-

nean brown forest soil; quality: 6

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: 1

Nearest water source: spring (‘Ain el-Meiyiteh, no. 86), 4 km distant

Nearest road: Tubas – Meholah (B8), 0.5 km distant

Visibility: 5

Dec. 16, 1982; 40 shards

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A site on a low hilltop on a range between Ras Jadir and Ras Mubarah, 2 km east of Taiyasir. In the foothills of this range, to the south, are upper Wadi Malih and the Tubas

– Meholah Road. There is a good view from the site of the *Yarzah* Hills and *Bezeq* Pass.

A modern family house, including sheep pens, now stands on the



200. Aerial photo of the site of Kh. el-‘Aqabeh, looking southwest. At the top is the road from Tubas Valley (right) to the Jordan Valley (left). The center of the site is on a rocky ridge, near the large house. Between the light colored path and the road is a Roman road. Winter 1994.

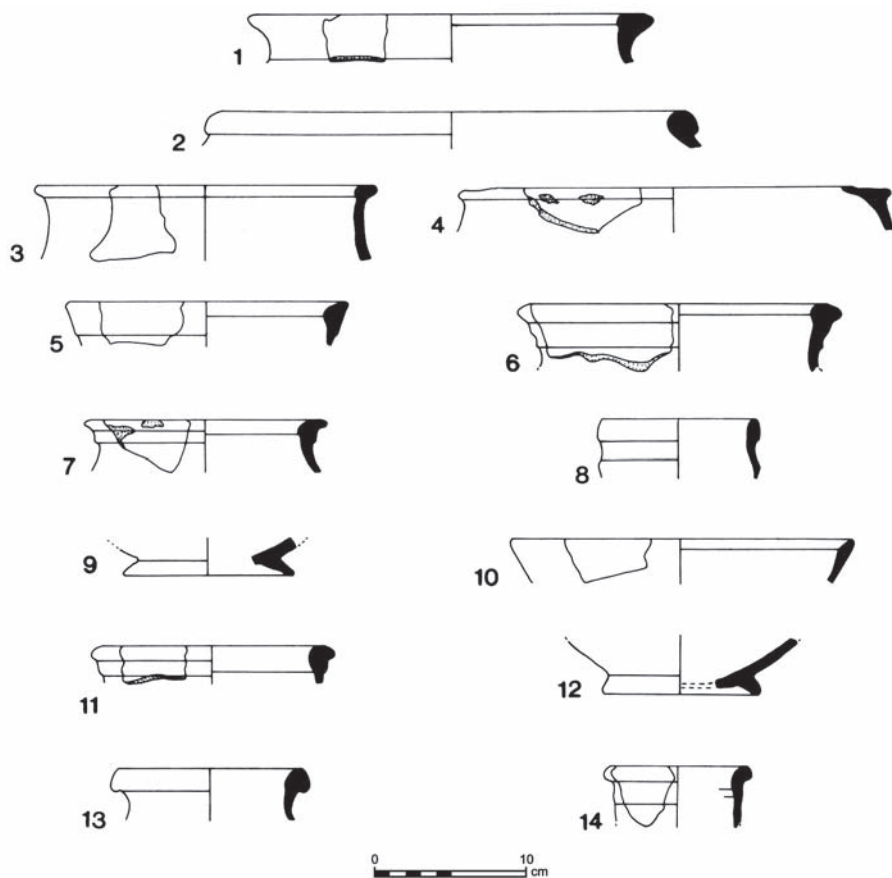
hill. South and west of the house, on the steep slopes that descend to the road, is a wall of large stones and covered with dirt. Apparently, it was used for fortification during the first period (MBA II?). On the flat hilltop are remnants of eight structures *in situ*, including walls and building stones. The central one is 6x8 m in size, built of especially large boulders and standing up to 1 m high. This architecture

is typical of the Middle Bronze Age in the region. Next to and north of it is a new stone wall built on ancient foundations, which encloses the modern structure. Nearby, the Roman road passes from the Jordan Valley.

Pottery: MBA IIB – 50%; Byz – 50%.

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: SWP II, 237.



201. Pottery from the site of Kh. el-'Aqabeh: nos. 1-12 – MBA II; 13-14 – Byz: 1. Jar, pinkish; 2. Folded CP, dk; 3-4. Craters, br; 5-7. Jars, pk-br; 8. Jug, br; 9. Crater base, yel; 10. Bowl, pinkish; 11. Jar, yel; 12. Crater base, br; 13-14. Jars, lt br.

Site 85: 18 – 19/93/1

Khirbet el-Khrebat (B)

Israel grid: 1899 1933

UTM grid: 7277 5802

Elevation: 250 m a.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small ruin

Area: 2.5 dunams (0.63 acre)

Topography: slope and ravine

Rock type: Judah formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 7

Cultivation: uncultivated and field crops

Cisterns: 1

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain el-Meiyiteh, no. 86), 4 km distant

Nearest road: Tubas – Meholah (B8), 0.3 km distant

Visibility: 3

Apr. 23, 1982; 33 shards

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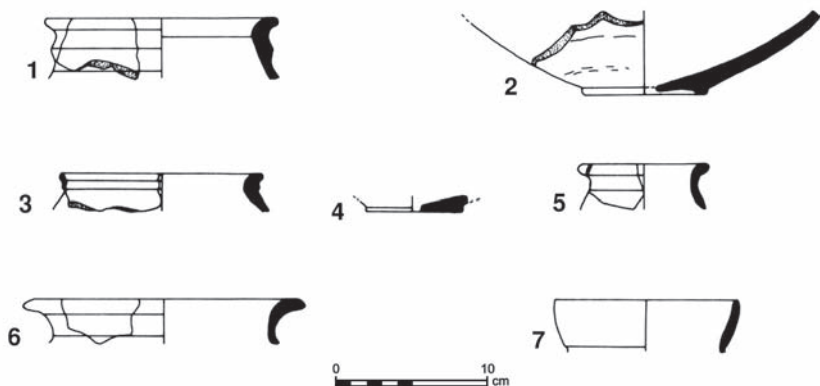
A site on a moderate slope descending southwards to the main road from Taiyasir to the Jordan Valley. Close by, to the northwest, is the site of Kh. el-'Aqabeh (no. 84) with its modern building.

The ruin is situated on several well built steps made of field stones. On top of them several square buildings, apparently domestic,

have been preserved. Next to and west of them is a hewn cistern with a fallen roof, approached by a hewn shaft and four steps. Above the site, to the north, is a good path to Kh. Ibziq from the Taiyasir – Meholah Road. Many, varied shards were found at the site.

Pottery: MBA IIB – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.



202. Pottery from Kh. el-Khrebat (B), from Middle Bronze Age IIB: 1. Jar, yel; 2. Big bowl base, lt; 3. Jar, br; 4. Bowl base, pinkish; 5. Jug, br; 6. Jar, pinkish; 7. Carinated bowl, lt.

Site 86: 19 – 19/30/1

Khirbet el-Khreibat (A) (on SWP map: Sufy al Khureibat)

Israel grid: 1930 1901

UTM grid: 7281 5799

Elevation: 230 m a.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.

Name type: historical place on map

Site type: small ruin

Area: 2 dunams (0.5 acre)

Topography: ridge edge and slope

Rock type: Judah formation

Soil type: terra rossa; quality: 7

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: 1

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain el-Meiyiteh, no. 86), 4 m distant

Nearest road: Tubas – Meholah (B8), 0.3 km distant

Visibility: 3

Apr. 23, 1982; 18 shards

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A small site on a southern slope, north of the road from Taiyasir to the Jordan Valley.

At the center of the site there are a large cave and a cistern. This complex is surrounded by a stone fence, apparently used as an animal

pen. Hewn agricultural installations were found, and a small shard scatter is spread over the slopes.

Pottery: IrA IA – 70%; Hel – 5%; Byz – 25%.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972, no. 78.



Site 87: 19 – 19/73/2

Tel ed-Diblaqah

Israel grid: 1970 1934

UTM grid: 7347 5807

Elevation: 35 b.s.l., 15 m b.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: farm

Area: 1.5 dunams (0.38 acre)

Topography: ravine

Rock type: Tiberias formation

Soil type: rendzina and Mediterranean

brown forest soil; quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain esh-Shaqq, no. 89), 1 m distant

Nearest road: Tubas – Meholah (B8 – northern branch), 0.4 km distant

Visibility: 1

May 9, 1986; 28 shards

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Structures and a courtyard, apparently a farm, in a low ravine, south of Wadi esh-Shaqq. It is located in a hilly area about 4 km south-

southwest of Meholah.

Next to a small gorge on the slope, remnants of a structure 10x12 m in size were found. Its plan is unclear,

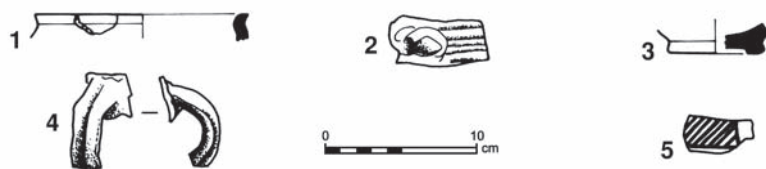
but it seems to have contained a courtyard and rooms. North of the structure is a circular courtyard 40 m in diameter, which reaches the gorge. The walls are of field stones. On top of the central building another structure was found, 4x4 m in size (a tower?), built of stones from the site; it appears to have

been built later. Walls of the site have probably been used as dams.

The site was presumably a farm with an adjacent animal pen, apparently built during the Iron Age and used also in later periods.

Pottery: IrA II – 45%; Byz – 50%; MA – 5%.

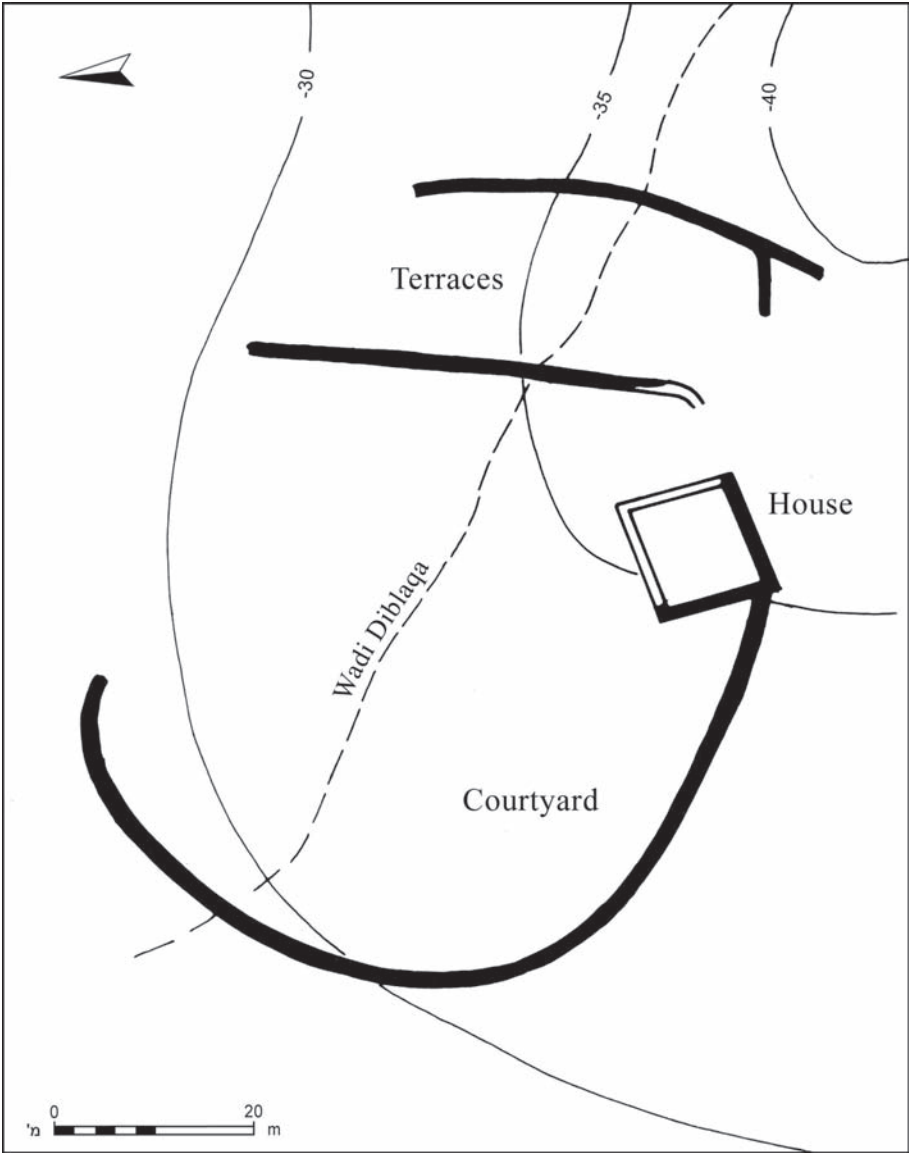
Previous surveys: none.



203. Pottery from Tel ed-Diblaqah: nos. 1, 3 – IrA II; the rest – Byz; 1. Bowl, br; 2, 4-5. Shards of jars, dk; 3. Bowl base, br.



204. The farm at Tel ed-Diblaqah, looking west. The farm buildings are left and around the wadi in the center. The place appears to have been chosen out of consideration for protection from the wind. 1986.



205. Plan of the farm at Tel ed-Diblaqah. Note the two dams\terraces in the ravine and the rounded courtyard.

Site 88: 19 – 19/73/1

Khirbet Wadi Qanat ej-Jamal

Israel grid: 1973 1934

UTM grid: 7349 5803

Elevation: 10 m b.s.l., 40 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small site

Area: 0.6 dunam (0.15 acre)

Topography: slope and hilltop

Rock type: 'Arad formation

Soil type: Colluvial – Alluvial; quality:

7

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 1

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain ej-Jamal, no. 134), next to site

Nearest road: Tubas – Meholah (B8), 0.8 km distant

Visibility: 5

May 9, 1986; 19 shards

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A small site on a low hilltop and on a slope descending southward into Wadi Qanat ej-Jamal, slightly north of Wadi Malih and about 2 km east of Hamam el-Malih.

On the site is a square courtyard or structure, 8x8 m in size, built of medium sized field stones. Walls

are connected to it on the east and west, and a cistern is next to the yard.

Pottery: LR – 100%.

Flint find: One item from the Middle Paleolithic.

Previous surveys: none.



206. The ruined structure of Kh. Wadi Qanat ej-Jamal. 1986.

Site 89: 19 – 19/32/1

Burj el-Malih

(on SWP map: Burj el Maleh; Guérin: Kal'at el-Maleh)

Israel grid: 1931 1928

UTM grid: 7311 5800

Elevation: 200 m a.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.

Name type: historical site on map

Site type: fortress

Area: 4.5 dunams (1.13 acres)

Topography: ridge edge and summit

Rock type: 'Arad formation

Soil type: stony basaltic; quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 5

Nearest water source: spring ('Ain el-Meiyiteh, no. 86), 1 km distant

Nearest road: Tubas – Meholah (B8), 0.5 km distant

Visibility: 8

Jan. 17, 1988; May 29, 1992; 62 shards

A fortress on the edge of a high, rocky ridge that descends from Ras Ramali into Wadi Malih, to the north of the Tubas – Meholah road.

This is a ship shaped fortress built on a northwest – southeast axis, 95 m long and 50 m wide. It is surrounded by a wall 2.3-2.5 m wide, built of two to three rows of medi-



207. An aerial photo of the Medieval fortress of Burj el-Malih, looking west. The road in the background leads to Taiyasir at right and to the Jordan Valley at left. Winter 1993.

um sized, hewn stones. In the south and west the wall is laid upon the cliff. The fortified gate, 2 m wide, is on the northern side. It consists of doorpost stones with hinge holes and a stone in which the joint of the gate pivoted. Beyond the gate is a fortified entrance room. Along the outer wall to the east a 20 m long inner hall, divided into three rooms, is discerned. In the smallest and easternmost of them is a round, built structure 2 m in diameter. Along the southern and southwestern side of the outer wall are two series of halls that run parallel to the wall. The northern one contains four rooms, while the southern one contains two. In the northern part of the fortress is a hewn pool, with

a wall along its western wall.

The masonry of the fortress is of small stones, coarse but relatively good. Two stages of building are clearly apparent: the original good building of ashlar, especially in the entrance, and the later building with small stones. The entrance and ceilings were originally arched (as Guérin and the SWP noted) but all of them are collapsed now. In front of the entrance, and along the entire outer wall, loopholes for firing are discerned.

The SWP describe “A fortress commanding the road down Wadi Maleh, and placed in a very strong position, with a fine view of the Jordan Valley...”. Other details are



208. The ruined gateway of Burj el-Malih. Within the entrance is a guards' room, in which the stone doorposts and loopholes have been preserved. Summer 1988.

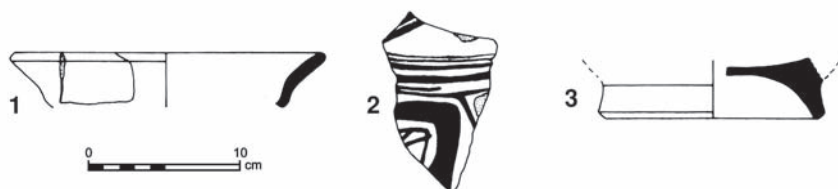
similar to our description.

This fortress was apparently built during the Crusader or Mameluk period, to guard the important pass from the Jordan Valley to the inner hill country and Nablus.

Pottery: MA – 100%.

Previous surveys: Gophna and Porath 1972, no. 83.

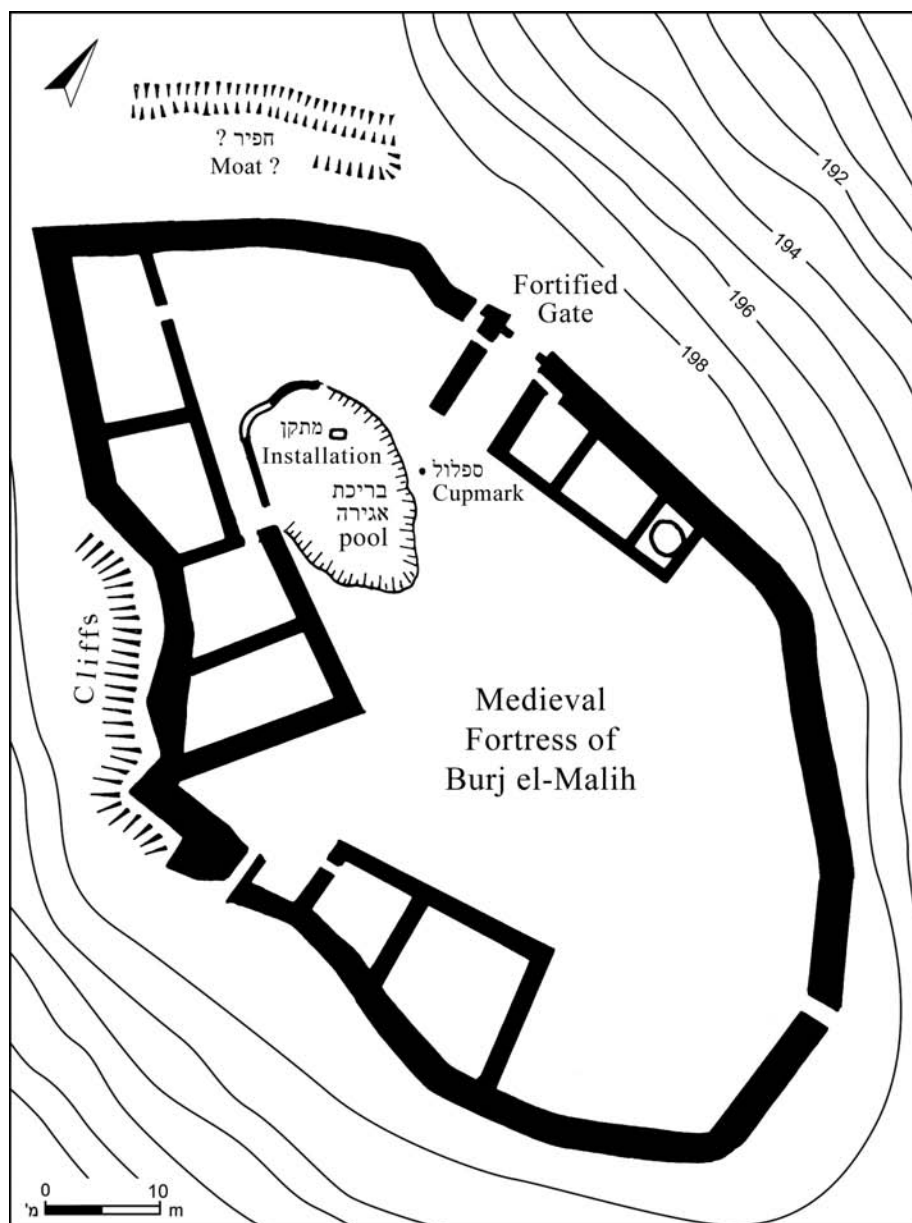
Bibliography: Robinson 1970, 403; SWP II, 235-236; Guérin 1969, (IV) 278-279; Ilan 1973, 351-352.



209. Pottery from the Burj el-Malih fortress, all MA: 1. Jar, lt; 2. Dec, br on wh; 3. Crater base, dk.



210. General view of the Burj el-Malih fortress, looking west. The photo was taken from the summit of E.P. 174. The fortress is in the center, with the peaks of Ras Ramali to the right. To the left of the fortress hill is the Wadi Malih pass. 1988.



211. Plan of the Crusader/Moslem fortress at Burj el-Malih. A large portion of the outer wall was left vacant, without inner structures, giving the impression that the fortress was in use for only a short time. Note the pool in the center. The last plan prior to our measurements was published in *SWP* in 1882.